

22. Codex Setup

Frontmatter

video_number: 22
folder_title: Codex_Setup
series: Building an AI Business From Scratch
video_type: Tutorial / Tool Setup
hook_type: Comparison hook -- Claude Code vs Codex
framework_phrase: Install, auth, code
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Reference Videos

- The Codex CLI Setup That Finally Made Sense (As A Claude Code Power User) -- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TqNzhJxHFjo>
- How To Use Codex CLI: Complete Beginner Guide & Tips -- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sTE0G95uElw>
- OpenAI Codex Tutorial #1 - Introduction & Setup -- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tlb_TzVNbDM

The One Thing

Codex CLI is Claude Code's direct competitor -- the setup takes 5 minutes and the decision of which to use takes longer.

Hook

Everyone's using Claude Code. But OpenAI just shipped a terminal agent that does the same job. Here's how to set it up in 5 minutes -- and what you actually give up.

Target Viewer

Claude Code users who saw Codex launch and want to know if they should switch, or builders evaluating their first AI coding tool.

Payoff

After watching, the viewer can install and authenticate Codex CLI, run their first task, and articulate the three key differences between Codex and Claude Code well enough to pick the right tool for their workflow.

Beat Structure

Beat -- 1 -- Why Codex Exists

Point: OpenAI built Codex CLI as a direct answer to Claude Code -- same category, different model, different philosophy.

Visual: Side-by-side terminal: Claude Code prompt vs Codex CLI prompt doing same task

Target words: terminal agent, o3, agentic coding

Beat -- 2 -- Install and Auth

Point: npm install -g @openai/codex, then openai login -- two commands and you're authenticated.

Visual: Screen recording: npm install, terminal output, login flow, confirmation

Target words: npm, global install, API key, auth

Beat -- 3 -- First Task

Point: Codex runs tasks in a sandboxed environment and asks for approval before touching files -- different default trust model than Claude Code.

Visual: Terminal: codex 'add a README to this project', approval prompt, file output

Target words: sandboxed, approval mode, task isolation

Beat -- 4 -- Key Differences from Claude Code

Point: Codex uses o3 (reasoning model), runs tasks in isolation by default, and charges per task -- Claude Code uses Sonnet, is session-based, and charges per token.

Visual: Split comparison table: model, cost model, default trust, context window approach

Target words: reasoning model, per-task billing, trust model

Beat -- 5 -- When to Pick Which

Point: Codex for isolated, well-specified tasks where o3's reasoning matters. Claude Code for ongoing sessions, complex multi-file work, and custom workflows.

Visual: Decision flowchart: task type -> tool recommendation

Target words: task type, reasoning depth, session vs task, decision

Analogy Bank

- Codex vs Claude Code: hiring a contractor (Codex -- defined scope, per-job billing) vs a staff engineer (Claude Code -- ongoing context, deeper integration). [concept: billing model]
- Sandbox mode: like giving a new employee a staging environment before prod access -- they prove the task works before touching anything real. [concept: default trust]

Thesis Line Location

Beat 4 -- the core insight is that the billing model and trust model are different by design, not by accident, and that difference determines which tool fits which workflow.

Framework Phrase

Install, auth, code

Specificity Bank

- npm install -g @openai/codex -- exact install command
- openai login -- exact auth command
- o3 model -- what Codex CLI runs on
- Claude Code uses claude-sonnet-4-5 by default
- Codex bills per task completion; Claude Code bills per token

Constraints

- Do not compare output quality -- this is a setup and decision video, not a benchmark
- Do not recommend one as universally better -- frame as tool fit
- Keep install steps to what's verified on macOS; note Windows differs

CTA Direction

Next video: once you have both tools, here's how I cut my Claude Code token usage by 90% -- which matters when you're running 10-hour sessions.

Personal Angle

[DANIEL TO FILL] -- e.g. moment you first ran Codex and compared it to your Claude Code setup, what surprised you most about the trust model difference

Vulnerability Moment

[DANIEL TO FILL] -- e.g. the time you ran Codex on a real project expecting magic and it asked for approval 12 times before finishing one task